

RAIL POWER



Union victory clearly “rode the rails.” Not only were Northern commanders able to use the railroads to transport heavy artillery to and from the battle zone, they also created mobile “railroad batteries” (above)—heavy guns mounted on flatcars, often protected by armor. Unlike horse-drawn artillery, railroad batteries could be fired on the move.

The North’s technological and strategic advantage in using the railroads was vital to its victory. In 1864, rail capacity was the sole reason that General William T. Sherman could contemplate his advance on Atlanta, despite Rebel cavalry raids that targeted Federal railroads. General Ulysses S. Grant’s siege of Petersburg relied heavily upon the efficient operation of the U.S.M.R.R.

Against the odds

For the South, the history of railroad construction and operation during the Confederacy’s brief lifespan was one of initial success followed by steady deterioration. President Jefferson Davis, like Lincoln, realized the significance that railroads would have and, in December 1862, the Confederate War Department appointed